

FIGHTING THE FLAB

Some widely used weight-loss drugs

ORLISTAT

It works by decreasing the amount of dietary fat absorbed in the intestine

- **Brand names** Xenical, Orlistat, Alli
- **Manufacturers** Various generic pharma companies
- **Cost** ₹85 for 30 capsules (generic); ₹3,900 for 84 capsules (branded)

LIRAGLUTIDE

Originally developed for diabetes management, it has also been found to have weight-loss effects

- **Brand name** Saxenda
- **Manufacturer** Novo Nordisk
- **Cost** ₹4,000 for one pre-filled injectable pen

SEMAGLUTIDE

Originally developed for diabetes management, it has also been found to have weight-loss effects

- **Brand name** Ozempic/Rybelsus (in India)
- **Manufacturer** Novo Nordisk
- **Cost** ₹2,800 for one 7mg tablet (Rybelsus)

PHENTERMINE/TOPIRAMATE

This is a combination medication that suppresses appetite

- **Brand name** Qsymia
- **Manufacturer** Vivus Inc.
- **Cost** ₹280 for 20 tablets (generic)

NOTE APPROXIMATE PRICES OF ANTI-OBESITY DRUGS. THEY NEED TO BE CONSUMED FOR A RELATIVELY LONGER DURATION FOR SUSTAINED RESULTS

SOURCE BT RESEARCH

these treatments due to concerns about cost and side effects. Despite this, these drugs are known for their high impact and yield so they are gaining prominence in diabetes treatment,” says Misra.

Doctors specialising in weight loss say drugs for diabetes help, but only for a certain BMI range (between 25 and 30-32.5, or just overweight) without any associated illness such as diabetes or high blood pressure. “If there are associated co-morbidities, medications have to be regulated, and monitoring has to be done more closely along with dietary changes and lifestyle modifications,” says Max’ Chowbey. Weight loss drugs cannot work for patients who are morbidly obese, that is, have a BMI over 37.5 kg/m² or 32.5 and above with some co-morbidities, he adds.

In November, the US Food & Drugs Administration cleared Eli Lilly’s drug Mounjaro, which was used for diabetes, for use as an anti-obesity pill under the name Zepbound. “While weight loss drugs can be beneficial, they are not a quick fix. For optimal effectiveness, these medications should be complemented with adjustments to lifestyle and diet. Whether opting for medication or surgical interventions, incorporating both diet and lifestyle changes is fundamental for a successful weight loss journey,” says Dr Sukhvinder Singh Saggu, Director, Minimal Access, GI & Bariatric Surgery at the CK Birla Hospital, Delhi.

Chowbey says, “Typically, anyone who is overweight, taking in consideration all medical parameters, may be advised diet modifications, lifestyle changes, exercise regimes and these medications as a treatment option.”

Given the business sense in making local versions of anti-obesity drugs, India’s pharma industry is in a rush. And India’s obese and overweight will not have to wait for long. Till then, they are stuck with expensive pills. **BT**

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